

Deer, giraffes, and camels

Around 20 million years ago, Earth's forests began to shrink as a new habitat—grassland—took over. This change encouraged the spread of plant-eating hoofed mammals, many of which had special stomachs able to digest grass and other rough plant foods. Such plant-eaters became very successful, and many species evolved, including not only the deer, giraffes, and camels on these pages but also sheep, goats, cattle, buffalo, llamas, antelope, and hippos.

Gigantic antlers

Powerful back legs
for running quickly

Megaloceros

MEG-ah-LOSS-er-oss



- **When** 5 million–7,700 years ago (Late Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Eurasia
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 10 ft (3 m)
- **Diet** Plants

One of the largest deer ever known, *Megaloceros* was about the size of a modern moose. The male had the most enormous antlers of all time—from tip to tip, they measured more than the total body length of a tiger. It used its antlers for display to attract females, as well as to scare off rival males. Like other deer, it shed its antlers every year. *Megaloceros* was hunted by primitive humans, big cats, and wolves, and died out 10,000 years ago.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- After swallowing food, deer, giraffes, and camels bring it up from the stomach to chew a second time.
- Three or four stomach chambers
- Head often bears horns or antlers
- Feet have even number of hoofed toes (except camels, which don't have hooves)

When

Even-toed hoofed mammals appeared about 54 million years ago, became widespread and common about 20 million years ago, and still exist.

